

Spotting Propaganda

 Red Level: I Want to Go Deeper

Name: _____ Date: _____ Period: _____

The Weaponization of Images

Every major conflict in modern history has been fought with images as well as weapons. Propaganda doesn't just support wars—it makes them possible by dehumanizing enemies and manufacturing consent. Understanding this history is essential for informed citizenship in an age of deepfakes and viral misinformation.

Comparative Analysis: Two Sides of History

Examine propaganda from **opposing sides** of the same conflict (WWI, WWII, Cold War, etc.):

Side A: _____	Side B: _____
How is the enemy depicted?	
What techniques are used?	
What emotions are triggered?	
What "truth" is claimed?	

Analysis: What do both sides have in common? What does this reveal about propaganda's methods?

Research Project: Visual History of a Conflict

Choose one historical event and research how BOTH sides used visual propaganda:

Options: WWI recruitment, WWII home front, Cold War, Civil Rights Movement, Vietnam War, any political campaign

Event chosen: _____

Key questions to research:

- What images did each side create? What images did they suppress or alter?
- How did visual propaganda shape public opinion?
- Were there counter-propaganda efforts?
- How do historians view this propaganda today vs. how audiences saw it then?

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Critical Questions

1. Propaganda often contains elements of truth. Does this make it more or less dangerous than outright lies? Explain.

2. Is there a difference between propaganda and persuasion? Where do you draw the line?

3. Social media algorithms show us content we're likely to agree with. Is this a form of propaganda? Why or why not?

Mini Museum Deep Dive

Research: How did newspapers expose spirit photography as fraud? Compare their investigative techniques to modern fact-checking of deepfakes. What's similar? What's harder today?

Visit: minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

Share with Your Family!

Interview Project: Ask older family members about propaganda they remember (wartime, political campaigns, advertising). How did they learn to recognize it? Has their media literacy changed over time?